If the Trinamool Congress thought it had effectively shut the lid on the teachers' recruitment scam that jolted the state a few months back, it was wrong. Less than 24 hours after West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee told the massive turnout at the July 21 'martyrs' day' rally at the Esplanade in Kolkata that she wanted to see her "party become the only idealist party in the country", her trusted lieutenant, high-profile TMC leader and minister Partha Chatterjee was arrested by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in connection with the teachers' recruitment scam on July 23. It was accompanied by lurid details: the ED, probing the money trail aspect of the scam being investigated by the CBI, found a huge cache of unaccounted cash—totalling Rs 21.2 crore—from the apartment of Chatterjee's 'close aide', 27-year-old model-actress Arpita Mukherjee. The bundles of 2,000 and 500 rupee notes are suspected to be the proceeds of sale of teaching posts for government schools.



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Chatterjee, who was education minister when the scam allegedly took place, was grilled for 26 hours; overnight raids revealed a massive number of property deeds, gold jewellery and foreign currencies in Arpita's name.

Arpita comes from a middle-class family in Belgharia, north Kolkata; her late father was a central government employee, her mother a homemaker. Though she modelled since her college days and was active in the Bengali and Odia film industries between 2008 and 2014, Arpita is not well-known in either profession. The only brand people remember her endorsing is Chatterjee's big-ticket community Durga puja, Naktala Udayan Sangha. "She was its brand ambassador and even shared podiums with Mamata Banerjee while inaugurating the puja. We knew her as Parthada's friend and naturally she held a lot of clout," says a resident of Naktala on condition of anonymity. She was also seen in some rallies, campaigning for a party candidate in the 2021 assembly polls and was also a regular at some political programmes.

Party spokesperson Kunal Ghosh said the party had nothing to do with her, as she is not a member. But the televised spectacle of heaps of money being hauled away in 15 iron trunks has stunned the people of Bengal.

The spectacle playing out on television, of heaps of money being hauled off in 15 iron trunks, has stunned the people of Bengal and embarrassed the TMC

THE ALLEGED TEACHERS' RECRUITMENT SCAM

The teachers' recruitment scam dates back to 2017-18, when the West Bengal School Service Commission (WBSSC) announced results for the recruitment of 17,000 teachers and for 5,000 posts in the Group C and D categories. Instead of publishing merit lists with marks, candidates had to check individual scores and ranks online. They sniffed a conspiracy, as there was no way to verify if the person being called for an interview and getting a job deserved it. Many moved the Calcutta High Court, seeking publication of the merit list. When the SSC came up with the updated list in September 2021 after a court order, it was found that many candidates with lower ranks had indeed secured jobs. One of them was Ankita Adhikari, daughter of minister of state for higher education Paresh Adhikary. One candidate, ranked 20 in the waiting list, complained to the court that she had been deprived,